

to chief. As a chief, he began a military campaign against the other islands and, aided by western cannons that had been acquired from Cook, he defeated the last of his enemies at the battle of O'ahu in 1795.

He has since been called "Kamehameha the Great," and indeed, many things he did were great. He was a wise ruler, revered the gods and their ceremonies, and made sure others also held this reverence. He created a reign of peace on his island under which citizens had rights of safety on all of his roads. Kamehameha's reverence for the gods extended to the Menehune, and they visited his court often. Though they had been very concerned during the wars, and many Menehune had died terribly from western iron, they forgave him and did their best to guide him.

Kamehameha groomed his son to take his place as chief, but Liholiho was not the man his father was. His failings and weakness caused the destruction of his society's underpinning: the kapu, and nearly lead to the destruction of the Menehune.

Breaking Taboo

Liholiho was a weak leader, and did not hold his father's convictions and belief in the gods. He also refused to listen to the advice of the Menehune. One of the longstanding taboos of the kapu system was that men and women could not eat together. Frustrated with this system, Kamehameha's favorite wife, Ka'ahumanu, teamed up with another of his wives to show that no disaster would come if the taboo was broken. The two wives invited Liholiho to eat with them, and he accepted.

Nothing happened. The gods exacted no retribution. When the people saw that the gods did not retaliate, something snapped. First their great god, Lono, was proved to be false, and now the taboos were powerless. Furious chaos descended over the island as sacred idols were torn down and destroyed. Many Menehune were slaughtered by mortals who saw them as allies of the gods. Life was bereft of meaning. The spiritual beliefs of the old days were dead.

Missionaries and Whalers

Whalers from New England found Hawai'i to be the perfect rest stop on the way to their hunting grounds in the Pacific. American Protestant missionaries from New England thought the whaling ships were the perfect transports, so that they could bring the good word to the Hawai'ians. The missionaries sought to instill their values of abstinence and stoicism in the Hawai'ians, while the whalers were just looking for a good time.

The Menehune tried to drive the missionaries from the islands, but they came with gifts and quickly ingratiated themselves to the Hawai'ian people. A small war for the hearts and minds of the Hawai'ian people took place between the missionaries who wished to convert them to Christianity and the whalers who wanted to drink all night with the local women. In the end, the priests won. In 1823, Queen Keopuolani was baptized a Christian on her deathbed, and many Hawai'ians soon followed her example. It is said that for every Hawai'ian who was baptized, a Menehune died — gone forever from the

The Gods

The ancient Hawai'ians followed many gods and goddesses, however, only a handful are still actively worshipped by the Menehune and handfuls of traditional humans. The exact nature of these gods and goddesses is unknown, yet they continue to have an impact on Menehune culture and beliefs. Perhaps they are what became of the mysterious first inhabitants of the islands. Or they may be a more powerful type of fae, or even chimerical beings. Whatever their true nature or purpose, it is best to be wary in the presence of one of these powerful beings.

Pele: She is the goddess of volcanoes, known for her passion, jealousy, and capriciousness. Pele travels the world in many guises, the most famous of which is an old lady wandering along the road, or scrambling over lava flats. It is wise to be nice to her, lest you find yourself trying to outrun a lava flow or engulfed in a cloud of sulfurous gases.

Kamapua'a: He is the pig god of the islands — a representation of unbridled male power, with all of its rampant and ungovernable emotions. Kamapua'a is notorious for causing great damage to the lands and forests where he rampages.

Pigs are vital to the Menehune, as they were to primitive Hawai'ians, not only as a food source, but ceremonially as well. A roasted pig is the center of every holy feast, and pig hunting is a holy activity, as well as a means of replenishing Mana (Glamour).

islands. For certain, the number of Menehune quickly diminished during this time.

The Call to the Spirits

As each Hawai'ian turned their back on the gods and the Menehune, and as each sacred idol was destroyed, a Menehune died, unable to survive the cold wave of disbelief. Now, when the Menehune revealed themselves to their friends — the fishermen and crafters of the islands — they were just as likely to be greeted with fear, or even outright hatred and hostility, instead of love. The missionaries convinced many people that the Menehune were devils, out to steal the Hawai'ians' souls.

As Menehune after Menehune withered and perished, the chiefs called for the survivors to retreat to the hidden and less populated places. They realized, too late, that the selkies had spoken the truth — all of the gateways and trods to Arcadia were closed. They were lost and alone, and would soon vanish for all time. The very last of the Menehune huddled in Moe'uhane, the village of dreams, singing ancient songs, carving idols, and trying their best to stave off their inevitable demise.

The Menehune called upon the ancient spirits of the island for aid. Their magic did not deal directly with these remnants of